



extend the blade, which would make runners faster in a way that isn't fair. That would almost be like doping," says Andrea Cremer, technical manager at Ottobock. So the evolution is limited to tweaks – for instance, adjusting carbon fibre layers to suit heavier athletes – rather than breakthroughs.

Popow believes even the current tech is enough. "The blades are already carbon fibre. That's stronger than the human body. Right now, the technology may be from the 1990s, but even that is far ahead of what humans can achieve themselves," he says.

But, he adds, the gap is narrowing. "The technology has not changed much since my time. What has changed massively is the professionalism of para athletes. Since London 2012, the education of athletes, coaches and technicians has gone up dramatically."

That progress has sparked debates about whether para athletes are now competitive – or

even superior – to their able-bodied peers.

Rehm's case is the most prominent. Alongside his Paralympic dominance, he won the German National Championships in 2014 and 2015, beating able-bodied rivals. But protests over a supposed advantage forced his exclusion from the 2015 World Championships team. Ironically, his personal best of 8.72m would have won gold at every able-bodied World Championships except 1991, when Mike Powell set the still-standing world record of 8.95m.

Popow, however, rejects comparisons. "How is it an advantage to lose your leg? Markus' disadvantages are far more than any advantage from wearing blades. But it doesn't make sense for para athletes to compete alongside athletes without disabilities. The mechanisms of force generation are completely different. You can't look at para sport through the same lens as regular sport."

He acknowledges why athletes want to be compared: it attracts fans used to the Olympics. But he argues this is short-sighted. "Para athletics is its own unique sport. The way to grow is to build up the sport itself."

And the performances continue to rise. "I started with the same blades athletes are using today. Back then, people wondered if someone could clear 5.50m in the long jump. Then it was 6m, then 6.50m. Now everyone is over 7.5m. And Markus is at 8.72m," says Popow. He believes a nine-metre leap is inevitable. "If someone jumps nine meters at the Paralympics, I promise you everyone will watch. I'm confident we'll see it before Los Angeles," he says.

And all of it, he insists, will be done with technology that has barely changed in 30 years. "It's like sitting in the same car as Max Verstappen. You won't become an F1 champion. It's not the technology that drives the human – it's the human that drives technology."